Learning Story 4: 'It Floats!'

Andrew and Gemma sat together during group time, their attention captured by the story "The Three Billy Goats Gruff". As Chloe, their educator, turned each page she exaggerated emotions and built tension and excitement into the story. The children were listening, their attention held by the dilemma, how could the goats cross the bridge to avoid the troll below? Chloe, watched and listened carefully, noticing the children's engagement. As the story ended, Gemma turned to Andrew and said, "Maybe they can't swim, so they had to go on the bridge." Andrew paused, then replied, "They could use a boat instead." Recognising the significance of this moment, Chloe made a deliberate pedagogical decision to follow the children's thinking. "That's an interesting idea," she said. "I wonder how we could help the goat cross the river without using the bridge?"

Motivated by their shared idea, Andrew and Gemma moved into the play space, bringing a small doll to represent the goat. An outdoor water trough of water became their river. Andrew placed a wooden block into the water and watched it sink. He said, "That one doesn't work." Gemma selected a small container and gently placed it in the water. "It floats!" she exclaimed. Chloe remained close, observing and listening. Based on what she noticed, she made another intentional decision to extend the children's thinking by introducing a range of materials. She provided an assortment of containers, take-away food containers, yogurt cups, and butter tubs, placing them within reach. "I wonder which of these might work best for your boat?" she asked. Andrew and Gemma began selecting, comparing, and testing the different containers, placing the doll inside each one to see if it would float and stay balanced. When one tipped, Andrew laughed, "It fell in." Gemma responded, "We need a bigger one."

Chloe noticed their curiosity growing and chose to introduce the class tablet to further extend their ideas. She asked, "Would you like to look at some real boats to get some ideas?" Together, they explored images of different types of boats. Gemma pointed to one image on the screen saying, "that one keeps the water out, it has a sail" Inspired by what they saw, Andrew and Gemma returned to their designs with new ideas. They selected different containers, tested them in the water, and adjusted their choices based on what stayed afloat and carried their doll. Throughout the experience, Chloe continued to make responsive decisions, when to offer materials, when to introduce new tools, and when to step back, guided by what she could see and hear in the children's play.






Andrew and Gemma said...

"Maybe they can't swim, so they had to go on the bridge."



"They could use a boat instead."



"That one doesn't work."



"It floats!"



"It fell in."



"We need a bigger one."



Gemma said...

"That one keeps the water out, it has a sail."



Chloe said...

"I wonder how we could help the goat cross the river without using the bridge?"

